

► An angel's gift

Dee claimed that the angel Uriel gave him this crystal in 1582. Symbols or spirits supposedly appeared in it, helping heal illness or predict the future.



right of kings: the concept, which persisted throughout the Renaissance, that kings and queens were semi-divine beings whose authority came from God. Many Renaissance monarchs embraced the idea of divine right. People thought that kings and queens held special powers, so they believed that being touched by a monarch, or touching a coin that the monarch had touched, could cure diseases such as the lymphoid illness, scrofula (known as “the king’s evil”). Great ritual ceremonies were held in which hundreds of afflicted people received a healing royal touch. The power of the monarch’s touch was seen as miracle-working and, as the king was considered God’s representative on earth, such rituals were presented as more religious than magical—although their exact status was ambiguous.

Speaking with angels

Thaumaturgy (the concept of working wonders or miracles) was central to the work of 16th-century British mathematician-occultist John Dee. He also promoted Enochian magic, a ceremonial practice that used a web of signs, symbols, and number codes to try to summon and commune with angel spirits, such as the archangels Gabriel and Uriel, in order to gain knowledge. Dee claimed, in effect, to contact the divine through a practice based partly on the apocryphal Judeo-Christian Book of Enoch, in which Noah’s ancestor, Enoch, is taught the mysteries of heaven. There was also an Enochian language, a special alphabet supposed to date back to the creation of the world. Dee used Enochian letter-grids, reportedly to communicate with angels, who spoke to him by selecting letters that formed sentences. He

► The holiest of tables

This is a 17th-century marble copy of Dee’s wooden Holy Table, complete with Enochian letters, with which the angels were said to spell out messages for Dee and Kelley. Dee made the wooden original in 1582 according to angelic instructions delivered to him via Kelley.

described his angelic conversations in several works, including his magic handbook *De heptarchia mystica* (1582).

Seeing the future

Dee developed complex number systems for his divinatory rites. The number seven was pivotal, partly because there were said to be seven planetary spheres. With Dee’s associate Edward Kelley acting as medium, the pair also used scrying devices such as mirrors or crystals (crystallomancy) to receive the teachings of the angels.

“O comfortable allurements,
O ravishing persuasion ...”

JOHN DEE ON NUMBERS, PREFACE TO EUCLID’S *ELEMENTS OF GEOMETRY*, 1570

